Code of Conduct and Reporting Policy

Internal draft - approval required before employee use

Effective date: Pending approval

Policy owners: People Operations and Legal

1. Our Standard

Northstar Labs expects employees, officers, temporary workers, and contractors to act lawfully, honestly, respectfully, and in the company's legitimate interests. This policy applies in offices, remote workspaces, electronic communications, customer settings, business travel, company events, and other work-related interactions.

Leaders are expected to model these standards, respond promptly to concerns, preserve confidentiality, and involve the appropriate company function rather than conducting an informal investigation.

2. Respectful Workplace

Harassment, discrimination, bullying, threats, and other disrespectful conduct are prohibited. Prohibited conduct may be verbal, physical, visual, or electronic and may occur through chat, video, email, social media, or an in-person interaction.

Sexual harassment includes unwelcome sexual advances, requests for sexual favors, and other unwelcome conduct of a sexual nature when it affects employment, interferes with work, or creates an intimidating, hostile, or offensive environment. Conduct can violate company policy even when it does not meet a legal definition.

Employees should not wait for conduct to become severe before raising a concern. Managers who observe or receive a possible discrimination, harassment, retaliation, threat, or safety concern must report it promptly to People Operations.

3. Conflicts of Interest

Employees must avoid situations in which personal interests interfere, or appear to interfere, with Northstar Labs responsibilities. Potential conflicts include outside employment with a competitor, a financial interest in a vendor, supervising a close relative, influencing a transaction involving a personal relationship, or using confidential information for personal benefit.

A potential conflict is not automatically a violation. Employees must disclose it promptly to People Operations or Legal and follow any written management plan. Employees may not approve their own conflict exception.

4. Gifts and Business Courtesies

Employees may accept an occasional lawful business gift with a value of $50 or less when it is not cash, a cash equivalent, requested by the employee, or connected to a pending selection or decision. Gifts above $50 require advance written approval from Legal. Cash and cash-equivalent gifts, including general-purpose gift cards, are prohibited regardless of value.

No gift, meal, entertainment, discount, or travel may be offered or accepted to influence a decision improperly. Stricter customer, government, or professional rules control when applicable. Employees should disclose repeated gifts from the same source even when each item is below $50.

5. Confidentiality and Accurate Records

Employees must protect confidential employee, customer, business, and technical information and use it only for authorized work. Security requirements in the Remote Work and Information Security Policy apply to conduct in every location.

Company records, including time, expenses, approvals, contracts, and reports, must be accurate and complete. Falsification, concealment, unauthorized destruction, and circumvention of an approval control are prohibited.

6. Reporting Channels

Employees may report a concern through any of these channels:

- Their manager or another trusted manager.
- People Operations through the internal service channel.
- Legal through the internal legal channel.
- The confidential reporting channel listed on the company intranet.

Employees are not required to report to a person involved in the concern. Emergencies or immediate threats should be reported to appropriate emergency services first, followed by the company when safe.

7. Investigations

Northstar Labs reviews reports promptly and as impartially as practical. The review may involve People Operations, Legal, Information Security, Finance, outside investigators, or other appropriate specialists. Employees must cooperate honestly, preserve relevant information, and avoid interfering with an investigation.

Information is shared only with people who need it for review, response, or legal obligations. Complete confidentiality cannot be promised. The company will document findings and take appropriate corrective action when a concern is substantiated.

Employees should not conduct their own forensic review of a suspected security incident. Under the Remote Work and Information Security Policy, suspected incidents must be reported to Information Security within one hour so evidence can be protected.

8. Non-Retaliation

Northstar Labs prohibits retaliation against anyone who in good faith raises a concern, requests guidance, reports possible misconduct, uses a protected right, or participates in an investigation. Retaliation includes termination, demotion, threats, harassment, exclusion, unfavorable scheduling, or another action intended to discourage protected activity.

A knowingly false report may violate this policy, but a report is not false merely because it is unsubstantiated. Suspected retaliation should be reported immediately through any reporting channel and will be reviewed separately from the underlying concern.

Non-retaliation applies when a concern arises during remote work, business travel, leave administration, expense review, or any other work setting.

9. Corrective Action and Questions

Violations may result in corrective action up to and including ending employment or a business relationship, subject to applicable law. The response will consider the facts, seriousness, consistency, cooperation, and prior conduct.

Questions about whether a situation presents a conflict, gift concern, respectful-workplace issue, or reporting obligation should be directed to People Operations or Legal before acting when practical.